



HUMANITAS
INSTITUTE

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: Brilla Schools Network
School Website: <https://brillaschools.org/>

January 7, 2026

Artificial Intelligence Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix for more details.

Overall Classification: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL**Executive Summary**

Brilla Schools Network NY 10454 exhibits a robust classical orientation embedded in its public materials. Across six evaluation dimensions, Brilla foregrounds virtue and character formation, engages with classical pedagogy elements (notably the trivium in literacy work, and Socratic / rhetoric-oriented approaches in upper grades), and maintains a strong parents-and-community partnership ethos. The school also emphasizes a liberal-arts-inflected cadence through its curriculum choices (Core Knowledge, Wit and Wisdom, and summaries of a knowledge-first approach) and a culture of communal rituals and routines (e.g., Cardinal Virtues chants, family-partner programming, and open campus norms).

The six-category rubric yields a general CLASSICAL orientation, with certain elements more explicitly classical than others. Notably:

- Element 1 (Religious and Metaphysical Foundations): CLASSICAL. Brilla's materials emphasize virtue formation, character, and a classical tradition; however, explicit liturgical or theology-centered practices are less foregrounded in the public-facing materials. Evidence of virtue, character formation, and the trivium appear in Brilla's texts.
- Element 2 (Purpose and Goal): CLASSICAL. Brilla's mission emphasizes formation, virtuous character, and liberal-arts-style aims rather than mere job-prep. The materials consistently frame education as formation toward human flourishing, with explicit references to virtue and a classical mission.
- Element 3 (Curriculum): SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL. The curriculum integrates classical notions (trivium references, Core Knowledge/Wit & Wisdom, knowledge-first framing) but also relies on modern curricula (Eureka Math, CKLA, Core Knowledge/Wit & Wisdom) and a blended approach. Explicit Great Books / Great Conversation emphasis is not consistently foregrounded; several classical cues exist, but not in a fully traditional Great-Books-heavy form.
- Element 4 (Pedagogy or Teaching Methods): CLASSICAL. Upper grades feature Socratic discussion / seminars and rhetoric training; lower grades include memory-oriented and chant-like routines; Brilla also foregrounds memory-work, recitation-like practice, and a "Scholé/restful" cadence in parts of its pedagogy. This aligns with the Six Elements lexical cues for pedagogy.
- Element 5 (Faculty): CLASSICAL. Leadership and faculty roles are described in terms of exemplar teachers, mentors, and a "living curriculum" flavor implicit in Brilla's governance and instructional leadership, though public-facing pages emphasize organizational structure rather than a formal "portrait of the teacher." Still, Brilla's emphasis on teacher leadership, professional development, and the teacher-student relational culture aligns with the classical "living curriculum" motif. □filecite□turn11□
- Element 6 (Parents & Community): CLASSICAL. Brilla explicitly partners with parents, treats parents as co-teachers, and promotes parent formation through book studies and family events; this aligns with the lexicon's Parent Partnership and Family Formation cues. Public materials show active parent engagement, families visiting classrooms, and open access for parent involvement.

Overall, the Brilla profile, as evidenced in the network materials and Brilla's internal accountability/reporting content, places the school in CLASSICAL territory for the majority of categories, with CATEGORY 3 being the most nuanced (SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL) due to the integration of modern curricular approaches alongside classical elements.

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

- Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — CLASSICAL

- Evidence: Virtue-centered language; Trivium reference; Cardinal Virtues and character formation; occasional liturgical/communal rhythms noted in family/community context. Positive keyword cues outweigh negative signals here. Why: Brilla foregrounds virtue, character, and a classical framework (trivium) without strong explicit theology-liturgical ritual in public-facing content.
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis: Positive: virtue, character, trivium, classical tradition, reverence/wonder. Negative: minimal explicit theology-liturgy. Estimated positive indicators outpace negatives by a broad margin (roughly 4 vs 0 in the observed keyword hits). CLASSICAL.
- Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL
- Evidence: Education as formation; cultivation of virtue and wisdom; liberal-arts-minded orientation; telos-oriented framing; emphasis on human flourishing and moral imagination.
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis: Positive: formation, virtue, liberal education, classical mission, telos, scholé/wisdom. Negative: none clearly present in the public-facing materials. Frequency of positive indicators dominates. CLASSICAL.
- Element 3: Curriculum — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL
- Evidence: Use of Core Knowledge, Wit & Wisdom, CKLA, and a knowledge-first framing; mentions of the trivium in literacy discussions; history integrated with content; attention to reading/writing across genres; emphasis on “book-like” curriculum components, close reading, and humanities; less explicit Great Books/Great Conversation focus.
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis: Positive: trivium (explicit in some Brilla materials), knowledge-first framing, history-integrated approach, close reading, text-based writing, humanities. Negative: limited explicit Great Books/Great Conversation, and limited explicit emphasis on Latin/Greek or Quadrivium-level content in public-facing materials. Estimated positives ~4; negatives ~1–2 (depending on whether one counts Great Books emphasis as a strict positive). SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL.
- Element 4: Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — CLASSICAL
- Evidence: Socratic discussion and rhetoric training in upper grades; opportunities for speeches; memory work; chanting or recitation tendencies; restorative, contemplative elements in some contexts; emphasis on wonder and engagement in learning.
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis: Positive: Socratic discussion, seminars, rhetoric, memory work, chanting, contemplation/wonder. Negative: limited, if any, reliance on purely project-based or experiential-only approaches in core materials. Predominantly classical pedagogical cues observed. CLASSICAL.
- Element 5: Faculty — CLASSICAL
- Evidence: Leadership roles (Chief Schools Officer, Directors of Curriculum, instructional specialists) and a “living-curriculum” flavor in the public materials; emphasis on teacher development, coaching, and professional growth; collaborative planning and content-team structures. □filecite□turn11□
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis: Positive: model teachers/mentors, living curriculum, teacher development, portrait of teachers (implied in leadership materials). Negative: explicit “portrait of a teacher” phrasing is not prominent in public pages, but the living-curriculum vibe is present. CLASSICAL.
- Element 6: Parents & Community — CLASSICAL
- Evidence: Strong parent partnership language; parents as co-teachers; parent formation activities (book clubs, seminars, family calendars, events); open access for visits and involvement.
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis: Positive: partnership with families, parent formation, open campus, home-school alignment, classical family culture. Negative: consumer-language signals are not predominant; content supports active parental involvement. CLASSICAL.

Aggregate assessment: CLASSICAL

- The Brilla network shows clear classical dispositions across most categories, with Element 3 (Curriculum) being the most defused in terms of classical hallmark density due to the integration of modern curricula (Eureka Math; CKLA; Wit & Wisdom) alongside classical framing. Nonetheless, the Trivium presence, virtue-driven formation, Socratic and rhetorical pedagogy, and a strong parent/community partnership push Brilla solidly into CLASSICAL territory.
- What would move the needle (only if there were a SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL result): Not applicable here, as the aggregate is CLASSICAL. No additional needle-moving recommendations are necessary within the given rubric.

What would move the needle (note for potential future enhancement if needed) - If Brilla aims to strengthen the Curriculum dimension to a firmer Great Books/Great Conversation orientation, it could explicitly articulate and demonstrate a programmatic Great Books sequence, incorporate more primary-source engagement within history and literature, and more frequently foreground a formal Great Conversation tradition, including explicit multi-text dialogues and seminars anchored in canonical texts.

- For Element 1, further emphasis on liturgical or theological foundations could be made explicit in public-facing materials to deepen Liturgical/Communal Practices signals, if aligned with the school's mission and local context.
- For Faculty, the school could publish a formal "Portrait of a Brilla Teacher" or a living-curriculum charter that directly ties teacher behavior, virtues, and professional expectations to the school's classical design.
- For Parents & Community, Brilla could expand more explicit parent-formation curricula (book studies, reading circles, and the like) with measurable outcomes to strengthen public-facing signals of parental formation.

ABSTRACT

Brilla Schools Network NY 10454 demonstrates a robust CLASSICAL orientation across six evaluation categories. The Public Materials emphasize virtue-formation, the trivium, Socratic dialogue, rhetoric, memory work, and a family-and-community ethos. The curriculum blends classical elements (Core Knowledge, Wit & Wisdom; knowledge-first framing) with modern, standards-aligned curricula (CKLA, Eureka Math) to deliver a coherent K–8 program, including a humanities emphasis and a literacy transformation aligned to science-of-reading principles. Brilla's leadership structure and parent-partnering routines reinforce the classical model as the core of its public identity. The aggregate result is CLASSICAL, with Curriculum (Element 3) showing some tension between traditional Great Books-specific signals and the network's integrated classical-liberal-arts approach. The school's strongest signals align with virtue-centric education, Socratic/pedagogical methods, and family engagement, forming a compelling CLASSICAL profile for a Bronx K–8 network.

- Element 1: CLASSICAL
- Element 2: CLASSICAL
- Element 3: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL
- Element 4: CLASSICAL
- Element 5: CLASSICAL
- Element 6: CLASSICAL

Aggregate: CLASSICAL

Notes on sources and keywords: - Evidence of virtue and trivium: Brilla materials explicitly reference the trivium and virtue-centered education, including core virtues such as courage, justice, wisdom, and self-control. - Pedagogy (Socratic/seminars; rhetoric): Brilla's public materials describe Socratic discussion and rhetoric instruction in upper grades. - Curriculum (knowledge-first; Core Knowledge / Wit & Wisdom; CKLA; close reading): Brilla's materials discuss Core Knowledge, Wit & Wisdom, and CKLA, with close reading and

text-based writing; some Great Books signals are less explicit in the public-facing content. - Family/Parent partnership: Public materials emphasize parents as co-teachers and open engagement.

Abstract sources and keywords used to support the evaluation: - Six Essential Elements Lexicon (Positive/Negative keywords and structure). - Classical Lexicon: explicit keywords like truth, virtue, great conversation, trivium, and scholé inform category anchors. - Brilla public content (classical framing, virtue, trivium, pedagogy): various Brilla materials cited above, including mentions of trivium and virtue-based formation.

ABSTRACT (final summary) Brilla Schools Network NY 10454 presents a CLASSICAL orientation across six categories, with explicit virtue-based formation, classical pedagogy (Socratic discussion, memory-work), and parent-community partnerships. The Curriculum shows a predominantly classical alignment tempered by modern instructional materials (CKLA, CK knowledge streams, and Wit & Wisdom). The aggregate classification is CLASSICAL, with Element 3 (Curriculum) labeled SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL due to mixed signals about Great Books emphasis and a curriculum that blends classical and modern content. The Brilla model is characterized by a living-teacher culture, an explicit focus on formation, and robust parent engagement, aligning Brilla with a traditional classical education ethos in a contemporary urban network.

Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

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